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Counselling and listening

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Most of us would perhaps agree that counselling suggests some degree of listening to other people's problems, and involves an element of advice-giving; of telling people what to do, or what not to do. The dictionary emphasises the aspect of giving advice or guidance on conduct, and most of us have a tendency to engage in this kind of activity, whether invited to or not. Typically, therefore, 'counselling' goes something like this:

- 'If I were you I'd invest in British Sugar' (financial counselling).
- 'If I were you I'd have that cough seen to' (medical counselling).
- 'If I were you I'd apply to study law' (careers counselling).
- 'If I were you I'd leave him immediately' (marriage guidance counselling).
- 'If I were you I'd give up sex altogther' (AIDS counselling).

Hearing versus listening

We tend to assume that because we are all 'counsellors' in the above sense we are all listeners, and that to a greater or lesser degree listening is 'natural'; an innate, inborn activity. However, this assumption confuses two fundamental issues: firstly, it confuses listening with our desire to be heard, that is, for others to listen to us; and secondly, it fails to distinguish between *hearing*, which is the perception of sound, and *listening*, which is the selective process of attending to sound. While the former is for the majority of persons an inborn and natural activity, the latter is an acquired skill which requires learning and practice. Indeed, listening is a highly complex skill which involves four separate but interrelated processes: attending, hearing, understanding

and remembering. Moreover, the acquisition of this skill requires motivation, because the amount of practice needed to attain expertise is almost always unsustainable without it.

The acquisition of listening skill, therefore, demands a certain attitude, and if this is of the 'couldn't care less' variety it is unlikely to sustain the necessary motivation. If you don't care sufficiently about something you won't make yourself open, or receptive, to it, and you won't give it your full attention. Moreover, caring has to be genuine, not forced or faked, because we tend to screen out those things about which we are unconcerned, or to which we are uncommitted. Most of us fail to acquire skills, not because we're incapable of doing so, but because we don't care to. However, even if we do care enough to want to listen to others, there are powerful factors at work within our culture which militate against our developing listening skills.

How often do you feel that you are talking to someone who is genuinely interested in you? How often do you feel that you are being given the attention you would like?

Most of us simply don't want the responsibility of hearing someone else's doubts, confusions, conflicts and pain, usually because we have enough of our own. Most of us don't know how to cope with our own strongly felt emotions, much less those of others, and we are embarrassed by declarations of fear, love, panic, pain; and by tears, especially those of a man. It is, therefore, simpler on all sides, and much less anxiety provoking, to maintain our social fronts or personae, to interact superficially and to remain unseen and unheard. Thus we collude in not really listening to one another. The problem is, however, that when we need to communicate with someone, and want to be heard, it is difficult to find anyone who is capable of actually listening to us. Unfortunately, many of those attracted to the listening professions – doctors, psychiatrists, priests, pastors and the whole gamut of professional counsellors – are so attracted because they see this as an arena in which they will be listened to (Jourard, 1971). Indeed, in many of the classic psychotherapies, often somewhat ironically referred to as the 'talking therapies', the client can hardly get a word in edgeways! Accordingly, counselling in its many forms tends to be seen as doing things to or for people; giving them advice, direction, coercion. Not surprisingly, therefore, it frequently attracts those with aspirations to power and dominance, with authoritarian personalities, and more than their fair share of egotism and self-righteousness. Counselling is thus often seen, and with some justification, as a do-good, interfering, busybody, know-all activity.

Carl Rogers

Given this, it is often very difficult for both would-be counsellors and their clients to realise that these features are totally incompatible with the theory

and practice of counselling advanced by the American psychologist Carl Rogers. Rogers is generally acknowledged to be the father of the counselling movement, and is perhaps the most significant contributor to theory, practice and research in the field of counselling and psychotherapy.

The Rogerian model rests on the fundamental assumption that no one can make decisions for another, act for them or solve their problems because these are matters of personal responsibility and choice. The notion 'If I were you' is therefore untenable, because one is not. Accordingly, any kind of change or action must proceed from the individual concerned. The assumption is that when a person accurately perceives their situation and themself within it, they become aware of their choices and have greater freedom to act. The role of the counsellor is merely to facilitate the person's exploration of themself, their situation and the choices available to them. In doing so the counsellor does not interpret, evaluate or judge.

How does the counsellor do this? Unfortunately, it is beyond the scope of this chapter to elaborate this fully, but it is Rogers's view that counselling is not about *doing* anything but about *being*. (For a fuller discussion see Graham, 1986.) Rogers claims that simply being caring, open and genuine is sufficient to establish the conditions in which another person feels free to be themself, and to explore and express their own point of view. Moreover, for Rogers, simply being attentive in this way is in itself therapeutic, bringing about positive changes which move a person in the direction of wholeness and health.

But is it quite so simple? The answer is, unfortunately, no. The attitude of non-doing in which the counsellor neither takes over a client's problems nor tries to solve them for him or her is quite alien to the Western world – with its obsessive concern for performance and achievement, especially for men (the majority of professional counsellors and therapists), who are particularly conditioned to the idea of 'doing'.

Jourard (1971) observed that one can discern among therapists a considerable dread of passivity because it constitutes a threat to masculine identity. Counsellors are therefore frequently attracted to 'manly', active therapeutic techniques which make them feel that they are doing something to the client that will get them well. This 'technical behaviour' almost certainly impresses the client, but, Jourard suggests, in striving to manipulate both himself and the client rather than respond openly and spontaneously, the therapist may provoke vigorous defences in the client which at best prove unproductive and at worst constitute an act of alienation and hostility.

This is no less true of attempts to 'do' things to put people at their ease, such as offering cigarettes or coffee, effecting certain postures and mannerisms, that are a feature of many would-be counselling approaches. Jourard observes that many people assume a 'professional' manner as soon as they are in the presence of clients or patients. These acts invariably put people on their guard, because they are aware that they are devices to manipulate them or the situation to the other person's advantage. Thus, despite appear-

ances to the contrary, such counsellors are attending to themselves rather than to others.

If one is to attend, or reach out (Latin *attendere*: to reach out), to others, it is necessary to put aside any barriers which may be in the way. Professional roles and personal mannerisms are only one kind of barrier. Others include one's thoughts, agendas, problems, concerns, preoccupations, assumptions, stereotypes, prejudices, opinions, needs and desires. In other words, the various aspects of one's self, or ego. Unless these can be overcome, despite all attempts to listen to others, one only succeeds in listening to oneself.

Reflecting the self

To the extent that the counsellor can put aside or suspend his ego, and withdraw his self from his encounter with another, albeit temporarily, the other person is effectively talking to themself, much as they might if speaking into a mirror. In so doing they may confront features of themself, possibly for the first time, and be able to use this new awareness for personal growth and change.

The concept of mirroring, or reflection, is therefore central to Rogerian theory; the counsellor being conceived as mirror-like, reflecting back the content and manner of the person's attempts at communication as faithfully as possible without the distortions that arise from egotistical involvements; that is, from the counsellor's hunches, theories, speculations, experiences, ideas on life, and so on. Rogers claims that, confronted with such sustained reflection, persons attend more closely to themselves and come to see themselves more clearly. Their awareness thus progresses from the general to the specific, from superficial to deep, from thoughts to feelings, from the abstract to the concrete. When these conditions are met there is ample evidence to suggest that the Rogerian approach is highly effective (Jourard, 1971; Rogers, 1980; Truax, 1963; Truax and Carkhuff, 1967).

However, at whatever level one analyses the concept of reflection it does carry with it a limiting feature – that is the nature of the 'mirror' of which it is a property. Rogers emphatically maintains that his approach is non-directive in the sense that attention is not directed to any particular feature of the client's attempted communication at the expense of others, just as a mirror is non-selective in what it reflects. Yet we know that human attention is selective owing to our limited capacity to assimilate information, and therefore it is always directed to certain input at the expense of others. The human 'mirror', and thus the Rogerian approach, is in fact highly selective. Perls (1976) indicates that it relies on feedback, and that Rogers 'only mostly feeds back the sentences, but there is so much more to be fed back'. Rogerian counselling thus ignores to a great extent paralinguistic features, posture, gesture, facial expression – indeed, the whole range of non-verbal communication and expression.

Even if it were possible to be non-selective or non-directive with regard to the verbal content of communication, the question arises as to how useful this would be. People tend to look only at those features of themselves with which they feel comfortable and to evade the more problematic ones, and it is simply not the case that sustained reflection requires the person to face up to the reality of themself. Therefore, in facilitating action and choices, the counsellor often needs to do more than merely reflect back what the person presents to them. Rather than facilitating a superficial and potentially misleading view of the person, the counsellor needs to be more like a magnifying glass, bringing certain features into sharp focus. For example, the counsellor may magnify the incongruence between verbal and non-verbal components of behaviour that occurs when a person declares their love for someone in a hateful manner; or highlight incongruence in speech itself, when a person contradicts themself or makes mutually incompatible statements.

Frederick (Fritz) Perls

Frederick Perls, the originator of Gestalt Therapy, did precisely this. Using a highly selective approach, as opposed to a 'non-directive' one, he moved the 'mirror' in close to the client – too close for the comfort of many. Perls recognised that comfort and self-awareness are usually incompatible, with the former usually leading to complacency and stagnation rather than growth and change. He was, therefore, highly confrontative, focusing on certain features of a client's behaviour or speech, and, consistent with the magnifying glass analogy, he would frequently enlarge upon these, exaggerating an action, word or tone, and getting the client to do likewise.

This approach is clearly open to the criticism that it is directive, coercive and manipulative, and to the question of how the therapist knows what features to select for this kind of scrutiny. The picture suggested – that of a highly attentive therapist straining at the leash so as not to miss anything of significance and with some clear idea in mind of what might count as significant – is misleading. Reik (1949) compares such selective interest, consciousness of aim and directed attention to a searchlight turned on to a piece of ground where the operator knows in advance what he or she is looking for, the direction from which the quarry will emerge or where something is likely to happen. This is in sharp contradiction to the passive attention implied in the Rogerian approach, which is reactive rather than directive, and which may be likened to a situation where the searchlight operator's attention is drawn to an area to which he or she then turns his or her attention. In this case attention follows perception rather than precedes it.

These metaphors represent two extremes of attending, the former directed to certain events and missing a great deal, and the latter missing much because

there is too much to take in and providing a mass of vague impressions. Reik advocates a midpoint between looking for specifics and not looking for anything at all, which he terms poised attention, and he likens this to the searchlight operator not knowing very clearly what he or she might find but having a good idea where to look. This sort of attention has been demonstrated to be effective in empirical studies by Mackworth (1950), who showed that when people knew in which quadrant of a visual field stimuli would occur they were far more effective at signal detection than when they were presented with an open field. In everyday life the effectiveness of this kind of attention is clearly demonstrated by poachers, and it is essentially this concept of attention which is promoted by Perls.

For Perls, the effective counsellor, rather like an experienced poacher, has a good idea where his or her quarry is to be found, although not necessarily what it is. He or she therefore attends not to what is clear cut and obvious, but to what is vague, hidden, covert and obscure. It is in these grey areas, these recesses, that personal meanings reside, that is, in the qualifications people make about things; in their use of adjectives and adverbs; in unfinished sentences and pauses; and in their non-verbal behaviour. As Reik (1949) observes 'peculiarities of voice, of glancing, often reveal something that was hidden behind the words and sentences we hear'.

An attentive person will be listening for these vague, grey areas where meaning resides, and in seeking to understand what another person means, and therefore who they are, will explore them, and enable the person to do likewise.

Training in listening

Being attentive is, of course, not merely the preserve of psychologists, but from the foregoing it should be clear that counselling is rather more complex than many people suppose, and not something that should be undertaken lightly. Psychologists can assist would-be counsellors in a number of ways. They can provide an understanding of the cognitive aspects of counselling and listening. For example, Barker's (1971) listening model provides a framework for the analysis and discussion of all aspects of the listening process, i.e. the communication context, language systems, reception processes, neural activity, perception and discrimination, cognitive and emotional processing, and memory.

Moreover, listening is a conditioned or learned behaviour and as such may be modified through instruction which utilises insight into these processes. Additionally, psychologists can provide an understanding of phenomenology (the study of the world of events and things as they appear to the individual), which is the crux of all counselling, and its methodology. They may also be able to highlight the defence mechanisms employed in interpersonal communication and relationships; strategies of dissimilation and cues to

these; non-verbal behaviours; anxiety reactions and manifestations of personality disorder or psychopathology; and provide insight into these and other issues.

My own workshops focus on developing awareness of personal barriers to effective listening. Having had the principles of simple and focused reflection explained, and the opportunity to discuss these issues in some depth, participants are invited to listen to truthful statements generated by others in response to a given topic, usually personal aggression. So, for example, one person might commence with the statement, 'I get really angry when people who see themselves in some kind of authority try to patronise me.' Another might begin, 'I find that I am frequently very aggressive towards certain kinds of women.'

Most 'listeners' experience difficulty in recalling this initial statement, irrespective of its length and complexity. This finding usually highlights, sometimes forcefully, the extent to which we tend not to hear others, and the social strategies we have adopted which promote this form of 'deafness'. However, with practice, problems of hearing and recall are usually quickly remedied. What proves difficult for virtually every 'listener' is for them to suspend those aspects of themselves that inevitably obtrude between them and another. Typically this occurs in a number of ways, such as the tendency to give advice, provide solutions, dismiss a concern as trivial or unproblematic, talk too much, fill silences which the person is using to explore their thoughts and feelings, offer explanations or snippets of their own experience, make statements for the person, complete their sentences, persistently ask questions, interpret the person's behaviour, speculate as to their motives, identify with their feelings, theorise about the nature of the person's problems, give them a problem they don't have and try to solve that, indulge in curiosity about the person's lifestyle, life history, relationships, guess their thoughts and feelings, pretend to understand the person, think about the effect they are having on them.

Other barriers to effective listening might include certain mannerisms, attitudes or anxiety. For example, some 'listeners' constantly interject with phrases such as 'I see' (usually when it is clear that they don't), and others may say 'Yes, dear', with all the patronising overtones that this implies. Others appear aggressive in their manner, or motherly or uninterested. Some may simply appear to be paying more attention to re-stoking their pipe than to their 'client'.

Generally, people find these features relatively easy to identify, although much harder to overcome. Frequently they find these insights threatening to their view of themselves, and requiring a close examination of their self-concept. Many find that this in itself is of invaluable help to their own personal growth and development, but others will retreat further behind the defence of their professional role, and technical and manipulative approaches to the client. However, the workshop situation is essentially experiential and it provides participants with the opportunity to test these strategies on others

and compare the outcome with those advocated in counselling theory. Group members provide feedback on how well they feel they are being listened to, and what features of others act as barriers to communication and understanding. In this way the 'listeners' – effectively every member of the group – are required to confront themselves, their degree of openness with others and their defences against such openness.

For most people this experience is initially salutary, highlighting not merely impediments to effective listening and, therefore, the barriers they erect between themselves and others, but also their own concerns, conflicts, preoccupations and problems. They quickly realise that self-awareness is paramount in counsellors, and that they themselves have a good way to develop in this respect. Therefore, rather than seeing the counselling relationship as a one-way authoritarian process, the recipient of which is the client, they come to see it as a relationship of equality and mutuality, a sharing, through which both parties may grow and develop. In such a process the counsellor is also moving, changing, developing, rather than a fixed point or static being, and as such must be open to and aware of those changes within themself as and when they arise. Clearly, such awareness poses particular problems for those who are attracted to the counselling role, because the role conceals their inauthenticity, lack of spontaneity and self-development, and it invariably prompts a consideration of motivational and ethical factors in counselling. So, effectively, the workshop situation itself reflects the principles of counselling psychology, moving the participants from the general to the specific, from the superficial to the deep, from thoughts to feelings and from the abstract to the concrete.

At the end of such a session, participants are usually in a position to recognise that attention can only be focused if it is free and not attached to specific concerns, and that most of us do not give attention to others for the simple reason that we are preoccupied with ourselves, and with our own concerns. They therefore appreciate that to become effective listeners they have first to free themselves and that this demands rigorous and sustained work on themselves. That this has not previously been grasped by many counsellors is reflected in the results of a survey I conducted during 1987 on three groups of professional and voluntary counsellors. Seventy per cent of those attending workshops such as those outlined above indicated that they had not previously given any consideration to the skills involved in effective listening. Nevertheless, 66 per cent had considered themselves to be good listeners. Perhaps not surprisingly, therefore, 92 per cent found that their view of their own listening skill had altered during the course of the workshop. Ninety per cent found listening to others demanding, and an astonishing 88 per cent reported that they found listening skills difficult to master in practice. Given all this, it is perhaps not surprising to find the following anguished and anonymous plea among the annals of the journal *The Professional in Practice: Skill Development*:

Listen
When I ask you to listen to me
and you start giving advice
you have not done what I asked.

When I ask you to listen to me
and you begin to tell me why I shouldn't feel that way,
you are trampling on my *feelings*.

When I ask you to listen to me
and you feel you have to do something to solve my problem,
you have failed me, strange as that may seem.

Listen. All I asked was that you listen,
not talk or do – just hear me.
Advice is cheap: 10 cents will get you both Dear Abby and
Billy Graham in the same newspaper.
And I can do for myself; I'm not helpless,
Maybe discouraged and faltering, but not helpless.

When you do something for me *that* I can and *need* to do
for *myself*, you contribute to my fear and weakness.

But when you accept as a simple fact that I do feel what I feel,
no matter how irrational, then I can quit trying to convince
you and can get about the business of understanding what's
behind this irrational feeling.
And when that's clear, the answers are obvious and I
don't need advice.
Irrational feelings make sense when we understand what's
behind them.

Perhaps that's why prayer works, sometimes, for some people,
because God is mute, and he doesn't give advice or
try to fix things. 'They' just listen and let you
work it out for yourself.

So please listen and just hear me. And, if you want to
talk, wait a minute for your turn: and I'll listen to you.

Discussion questions

1 What are the possible limitations of the Rogerian counsellors' tendency to accept clients 'at face value'?
2 Exercise: Listen to someone for two minutes giving them your full attention; then two minutes of half attention; then two minutes of no attention. What effect does this have on the speaker? What kinds of